POLICY PAPER

School District Consolidation in Rhode Island:

A Case for Voluntary, Incentive-Driven Regionalization

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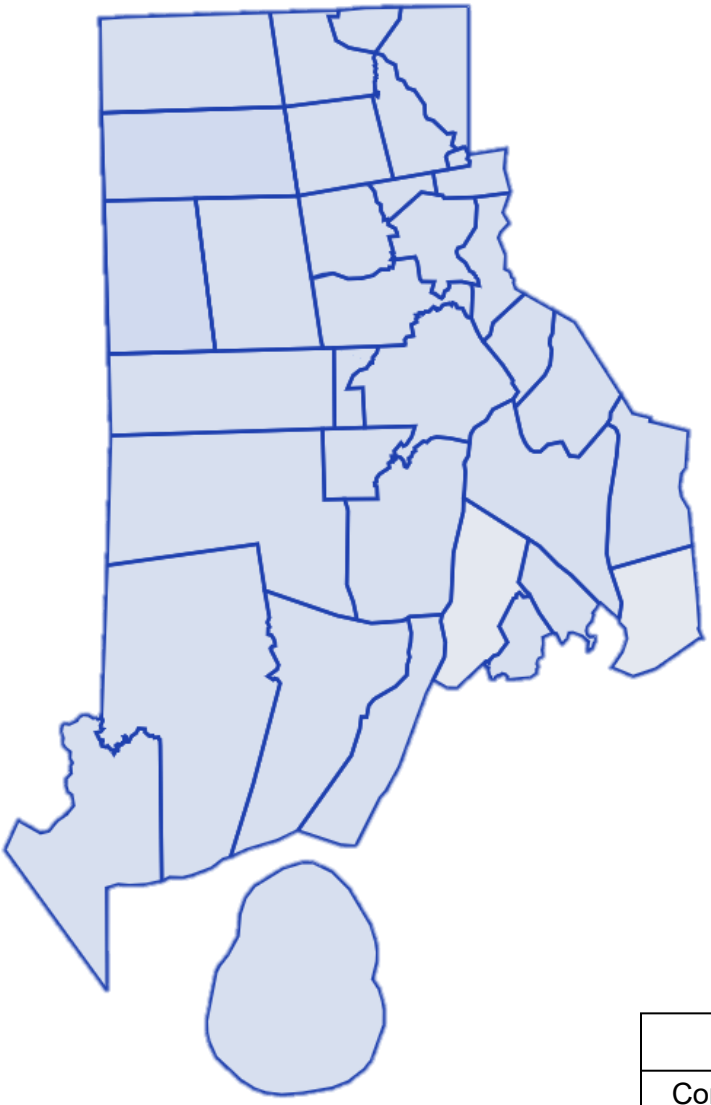

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Connect to the app to model Consolidation Savings/Costs

Executive Summary

Rhode Island operates 36 municipal school districts across 39 municipalities in one of the nation's smallest states. The result is a patchwork of small, fragmented administrative units that increasingly struggle under the weight of declining enrollment, rising per-pupil costs, pension obligations, and inequitable resource distribution. This paper argues that Rhode Island should expand its regional school district model by enacting a voluntary, incentive-driven consolidation policy targeting municipalities with school enrollment below 1,000 students (New Shoreham, Little Compton, Foster, Jamestown, Glocester, Narragansett).

Our recommendation is grounded in a critical review of the national consolidation research literature, including natural experiments in Arkansas and North Carolina, and comparative state-level analyses in Vermont, Massachusetts, and Connecticut, alongside Rhode Island-specific evidence from RIPEC, RIDE fiscal reports, and the Aquidneck Island Consolidation Feasibility Study. We find that while consolidation carries real risks (particularly around labor contract leveling-up, transportation costs, and community identity), well-designed voluntary programs that pair financial incentives with community planning processes can unlock fiscal savings, broaden curricular offerings, and improve equity, particularly for small rural districts below the 1,000-student threshold identified in the literature.

We propose a three-phase implementation framework modeled on Rhode Island's existing Chariho Regional District and Vermont's Act 46, with robust financial incentives, a 5-year rolling enrollment cost-sharing mechanism (already piloted in Exeter-West Greenwich), and RIDE-led regional planning boards for eligible districts. We acknowledge key implementation uncertainties, especially around labor negotiations and local political resistance, and we recommend pilot consolidations in southern Rhode Island before statewide scaling.

Rhode Island School District Enrollment & Budget Ranked (FY 2026)

Rank	District	Enroll.	Budget	$/Pupil	Rank	District	Enroll.	Budget	$/Pupil
1	New Shoreham	126	$6,106,984	$48,468	19	East Greenwich	2,490	$50,185,330	$20,154
2	Little Compton	218	$9,026,130	$41,404	20	Central Falls	2,560	$54,365,494	$21,236
3	Foster	241	$4,965,550	$20,605	21	Bristol Warren	2,693	$60,953,635	$22,634
4	Jamestown	406	$16,456,618	$40,534	22	Chariho	2,966	$82,972,790	$27,977
5	Glocester	563	$9,901,109	$17,586	23	Johnston	3,191	$73,317,453	$22,978
6	Narragansett	977	$39,521,834	$40,452	24	Lincoln	3,278	$71,149,479	$21,705
7	Scituate	1,194	$26,232,817	$21,970	25	Barrington	3,294	$67,545,120	$20,505
8	Foster-Glocester	1,273	$27,304,858	$21,450	26	West Warwick	3,469	$80,107,981	$23,095
9	Tiverton	1,520	$37,390,326	$24,599	27	North Providence	3,488	$65,669,577	$18,825
10	Exeter-West Greenwich	1,544	$38,525,888	$24,952	28	North Kingstown	3,786	$79,788,066	$21,079
11	North Smithfield	1,637	$33,922,618	$20,721	29	Coventry	4,056	$83,565,565	$20,604
12	Newport	1,795	$48,470,044	$27,003	30	Cumberland	4,881	$78,910,633	$16,168
13	Middletown	1,860	$46,279,270	$24,881	31	East Providence	5,225	$99,398,450	$19,024
14	Burrillville	1,993	$38,052,800	$19,093	32	Woonsocket	5,541	$110,411,555	$19,928
15	Portsmouth	2,134	$50,230,242	$23,535	33	Pawtucket	7,816	$138,030,108	$17,659
16	Westerly	2,139	$63,556,652	$29,713	34	Warwick	7,853	$198,167,317	$25,235
17	South Kingstown	2,253	$68,583,634	$30,441	35	Cranston	10,037	$189,388,837	$18,870
18	Smithfield	2,361	$49,140,885	$20,814	36	Providence	20,250	$445,048,116	$21,977

I. Introduction: Rhode Island's Fragmented School Governance

Rhode Island presents an unusual case in American education governance. With only 39 municipalities and approximately 136,000 public school students (RIDE, 2025), the state nonetheless supports 66 Local Education Agencies. These agencies consist of 36 traditional school districts (including the four existing regional districts) and 30 public schools of choice, such as charter and vocational schools.

RIDE's FY2024 Fiscal Accountability Report found that statewide per-pupil spending in traditional districts grew by 2.9% from the prior year. However, spending on core instructional functions declined over the past five years. The report noted that, “Non-core areas, including transportation, out-of-district tuition, building maintenance, and post-employment benefits, are consuming a growing share of district budgets.”

Among traditional districts, per-pupil spending ranges from $16,168 to $48,468, a nearly 3x spread (RIDE, 2025). This variation reflects the economies of scale and different spending habits in a highly fragmented system. Rhode Island’s highest per-pupil spending districts tend to be the smallest, where fixed costs like central administration, special education staffing, and facilities are spread across fewer students. Declining enrollment intensifies this dynamic by pushing fixed costs onto an even smaller student base each year. In addition, several small districts do not operate their own high school and already pay tuition to send students elsewhere, meaning key components of secondary education are functionally regionalized even when governance remains municipal. Together, these features suggest that Rhode Island’s current district structure produces predictable fiscal pressure in small communities and strengthens the case for voluntary regionalization.

Rhode Island faces a structural crisis. State Rep. Megan Cotter, who represents Exeter-West Greenwich and Chariho, two of Rhode Island’s regional districts, has introduced 2026 legislation to substantially increase state financial incentives for districts that voluntarily regionalize. (House Bill 7207 / H 7318)

This paper identifies school district consolidation, specifically, the voluntary merger of small municipal districts into regional school districts, as a promising but carefully conditioned policy lever to address these pressures. Our central question: Under what conditions, and with what policy design, can Rhode Island use district regionalization to improve fiscal efficiency and educational quality without sacrificing local community identity or harming student outcomes?

II. Problem Definition: Negative Impacts of Fragmentation

We will examine the issue of Rhode Island's district fragmentation along three dimensions: fiscal efficiency, student outcomes, and community effects.

A. The Efficiency Problem

Administrative fragmentation in Rhode Island decreases the efficiency of fund allocation. With statewide enrollment declining and projected to continue falling, fixed administrative and facility costs are spread across fewer students, driving up per pupil expenditures. Small districts are especially vulnerable. A district of 1000 students (like Narragansett) must fund a superintendent, special education director, and central office infrastructure regardless of whether it can achieve scale efficiencies.

This dynamic has been widely documented in New England. The Federal Reserve Bank of Boston (2020) finds that declining school age populations combined with rising fixed costs threaten the long-term sustainability of small districts across northern New England. Rhode Island faces similar demographic pressures, although its smaller geographic footprint reduces transportation challenges relative to more rural states. Evidence from other states reinforces the scale problem. A California Legislative Analyst's Office report found that very small districts, defined as fewer than 200 students, allocate a substantially larger share of spending to administrative overhead than larger districts, which devote a higher proportion of expenditures to instruction (Taylor, 2011). Economies of scale are therefore most pronounced at very small enrollment levels.

At the same time, consolidation does not automatically generate savings. Gordon and Knight (2008) find that administrative mergers without corresponding school closures produce little evidence of cost reduction, suggesting that fixed costs persist unless districts actively restructure facilities and staffing. Similarly, Rhode Island specific feasibility studies, including RIPEC's Aquidneck Island analysis (2009), caution that projected savings depend heavily on design choices, including whether redundant facilities are closed and how labor contracts are aligned. These findings suggest that the relevant policy question is not whether consolidation guarantees savings, but whether carefully designed regionalization paired with administrative rightsizing and cost discipline can unlock efficiencies in districts operating below sustainable scale.

B. Impact on Student Outcomes

A California Legislative Analyst's Office (LAO) report notes that small districts are "more difficult to hold accountable for student outcomes because their small enrollments do not yield statistically significant results" (Taylor, 2011). The report recommends the state to raise the minimum district size threshold to at least 100 students.

The more consistent impact of scale relates to program availability and stability. Small districts often lack sufficient enrollment to sustain advanced placement courses, career and technical education pathways, arts programming, and specialized services. Limited enrollment can also increase volatility in performance metrics, as small cohort sizes amplify year-to-year fluctuations. Fragmentation therefore does not inherently reduce achievement, but it can constrain curricular breadth and operational stability in districts operating below sustainable scale. The student outcome case for regionalization rests primarily on expanding access and stabilizing programming rather than on immediate test score improvements.

C. Community Effects

Beyond costs and curriculum, fragmentation shapes how communities govern themselves. Rhode Island's districts are deeply embedded in municipal identity, each town runs its own school committee, budget cycle, elections, and administrative leadership. That structure preserves genuine local voice, but it also multiplies overhead and inhibits the kind of regional coordination that long-term planning, transportation, and shared services require. Small districts compound the problem: they struggle to attract and keep experienced administrators, leaving them with thin governance capacity and limited institutional memory.

None of this means fragmentation is simply wrong. Schools are civic anchors, and the concern that regionalization dilutes local representation is legitimate and deserves to be taken seriously in any policy design. The honest framing is a tradeoff, fragmentation protects municipal autonomy at the cost of coordinated, professionalized governance. The question is whether that tradeoff still makes sense at current enrollment levels.

III. Evidence For and Against Consolidation

A. Fiscal Efficiency: Mixed Evidence with Important Considerations

The strongest fiscal case for consolidation applies specifically to very small districts. Duncombe and Yinger (2007), in a study published in Education Finance and Policy, found that economies of scale in education are most pronounced for districts below 1,500 students and largely disappear above that threshold. For districts with enrollment below 1,000, the evidence for positive net fiscal benefits from consolidation is reasonably strong. Above 1,500 students, the same study found evidence of diseconomies of scale.

Gordon and Knight (2008) examined Iowa school district consolidations in the 1990s. Since districts already shared schools before consolidation, the mergers offer an opportunity to isolate the effects of administrative consolidation. The study found no significant efficiency gains from administrative reorganization.

The Vermont experience is particularly instructive given its demographic and geographic similarities to Rhode Island. Vermont's Act 46 (2015) was an ambitious consolidation initiative that reduced the state from 273 to approximately 119 districts. An independent Yale thesis analyzing the Act 46 mergers found no significant change in overall spending or local tax rates from the consolidations, and the cost-per-pupil may have increased post-merger, largely driven by salary and benefit leveling-up across merged labor contracts (Miller,2024) . A VT Digger report on the same thesis confirmed that larger district governance structures in Vermont did not perform better on cost or outcome metrics (2024). The central lesson from Vermont: consolidation increases spending when contracts are renegotiated upward and when school buildings are not closed.

Key Research Finding: The 1,000-Student Threshold

Duncombe & Yinger (2007) provide the most rigorous guidance: strong evidence for net fiscal benefits from consolidation exists only for districts with enrollment below approximately 1,000 students. States should resist one-size-fits-all consolidation mandates, and incentive programs should be calibrated to district size. Rhode Island should focus its consolidation policy on its smallest districts.

B. Student Academic Outcomes: Mostly Null, With Nuance

A rigorous natural experiment in Arkansas provides the cleanest evidence on student outcomes. Arkansas Act 60 (2003) mandated consolidation of all districts with fewer than 350 students for two consecutive years. McGee, Mills, and Goldstein (2023), using a regression discontinuity design, found that consolidation had either null or very small positive impacts on student achievement in math and English Language Arts. The authors concluded that Act 60 did not appear to help students much, but also did not harm them.

Research from North Carolina (Chin, 2023) found that per-pupil expenditures on instruction and district support services decreased following consolidation, and schools became more racially integrated. However, youth exposed to mergers showed no improvement in later-life criminal

justice outcomes. Mississippi consolidations between 2014 and 2018 showed declining standardized test scores post-merger, a more troubling finding, though the Mississippi context (very high poverty, multiple concurrent policy changes) makes clean attribution difficult (Camel, 2019).

The National Education Policy Center's 2011 synthesis of the consolidation literature cautions that a century of consolidation has already produced most obtainable efficiency gains, and that in larger jurisdictions, diseconomies may have set in. For Rhode Island, this means consolidation policy should be targeted, not a wholesale reorganization, and that academic outcome monitoring must be built into any implementation framework.

There is one consistent educational quality argument in favor of consolidation: expanded curricular breadth. Small districts frequently cannot offer advanced placement courses, foreign languages, arts, music, CTE pathways, or specialized services (gifted, ESL, special education) that the level larger districts can. In Connecticut, research by Democrats for Education Reform found that regional high schools academically outperformed their community high school counterparts, and identified approximately 2,800 students as the ideal district size for output efficiency (Dowell, 2022). Rhode Island's Rep. Cotter has noted that regional districts like Exeter-West Greenwich can offer double the career technical and AP class options of their standalone counterparts.

C. Community Identity and Social Costs: The Underappreciated Countervailing Force

The most consistent finding across qualitative consolidation research is that community identity, particularly in small, rural towns, poses a powerful political and social constraint. Schools are not just administrative units; they are community anchors, sources of local identity, and hubs for civic participation. RIPEC research found that regionalized districts have historically struggled to generate the administrative savings advocates promised, partly because neither administrators nor communities were willing to close buildings or reduce headcount.

A study of housing values by Brasington (2004) found that households placed negative value on certain features of consolidation, even when fiscal benefits were present. This has a direct policy implication: voter approval processes for consolidation tend to fail unless the specific community concerns (school closures, athletic rivalries, local identity) are explicitly addressed in the proposal design.

Summary of Key Research Studies

Study	Setting / Method	Key Finding for RI Policy

Duncombe & Yinger (2007)	National synthesis; NY district data	Strong fiscal case for consolidation only below ~1,000 students
McGee et al. (2023)	Arkansas Act 60; regression discontinuity	Null/small positive effects on student achievement; no harm
Gordon & Knight (2008)	Iowa 1990s consolidations	No efficiency gains without school closures
Schueler (2023)	North Carolina county mergers	Lower per-pupil instruction costs; more racial integration
Vermont Act 46 Yale thesis (2025)	Vermont statewide mergers	No spending savings; per-pupil costs rose due to labor leveling
RIPEC (2022)	RI regional vs. municipal districts	Regional districts historically had higher per-pupil costs
Aquidneck Island Study (2009)	Newport/Middletown/Portsmouth, RI	Feasibility found; expanded offerings; savings contingent on design
Nat. Education Policy Ctr. (2011)	National literature review	A century of consolidation may have exhausted major efficiencies

IV. The Rhode Island Context: Local Evidence and Precedents

A. Existing Regional Districts as Evidence

Rhode Island's four existing regional school districts provide in-state evidence. Chariho Regional School District, formed from Charlestown, Richmond, and Hopkinton, is the state's most prominent example. Using a five-year rolling average enrollment cost-sharing formula that adjusts for demographic shifts between towns (Chariho, 2022), Chariho has provided students in three small rural towns access to a comprehensive high school curriculum that no single town could have sustained independently. Rep. Cotter, who represents Chariho and Exeter-West Greenwich, has described the five-year rolling average mechanism as "a fabulous model" for equitable cost allocation between member towns.

The RIPEC Aquidneck Island Consolidation Feasibility Study (commissioned in 2009 for Middletown, Newport, and Portsmouth) found that consolidation could expand the critical mass of students for wider academic and extracurricular offerings, generate potential revenue from land sales of redundant properties, and enable administrative savings, though RIPEC was careful to note that savings are contingent on specific design choices, including whether buildings are closed and how labor contracts are renegotiated. Newport and Middletown had twice attempted and failed to merge in the prior 20 years, underscoring the political challenge.

B. Current Legislative Momentum

As of early 2026, school regionalization has returned to the top of Rhode Island's education policy agenda. RI Commissioner Angelica Infante-Green has publicly acknowledged that having "two elementary schools and two districts side-by-side that are half empty" is unsustainable (Ocean State Media, 2026) , while stressing that community engagement must drive any consolidation process. Rep. Cotter's legislation to triple state education funding for districts that voluntarily regionalize represents the most concrete legislative vehicle in recent years. The RI Foundation Blue Ribbon Commission (January 2026) called for comprehensive reform of the state funding formula, noting that the current system, in which the state covers only 38% of K-12 spending (Blue Ribbon Commission, 2026), insulates some districts from the fiscal pressure to consolidate while leaving urban core districts under-resourced.

C. Rhode Island General Law: Existing Consolidation Infrastructure

Rhode Island General Law Section 16-3-3.1 already establishes a legal framework for ordered regionalization studies. The Commissioner of Elementary and Secondary Education is authorized to mandate a regional school district planning board if: (1) high school enrollment is projected to fall below 100 per grade; (2) per-pupil spending falls to 66% or less of the statewide average for three consecutive years; (3) the community lacks fiscal capacity to provide BEP-compliant education; or (4) the district cannot meet Basic Education Program requirements. This framework provides a ready-made legal mechanism that a strengthened incentive program can build upon, both for voluntary consolidations and, in extreme cases, state-ordered planning.

V. Policy Recommendation: A Voluntary, Incentive-Driven Regionalization Framework

Based on the national research literature and Rhode Island-specific context, we recommend that the Rhode Island General Assembly enact a Voluntary Regionalization Incentive Act (VRIA) targeting small municipal school districts. Our recommendation emphasizes voluntarism, financial incentives calibrated to district size, community-driven planning, and a phased implementation approach, drawing lessons from Vermont's Act 46 (what to avoid) and Chariho/Exeter-West Greenwich (what to replicate).

A. Target Eligibility: Focus on Districts Below the Evidence-Based Threshold

The policy should prioritize districts with average daily enrollment below 1,000 students (New Shoreham, Little Compton, Foster, Jamestown, Glocester, Narragansett), consistent with the strongest evidence for fiscal benefits from the Duncombe-Yinger framework. Secondary eligibility criteria should include districts with high school enrollment projected to fall below 150 students per grade within five years, or districts in the top quartile of per-pupil administrative spending (Tiverton, North Smithfield, Exeter-West Greenwich, Scituate, Middletown, Newport, Portsmouth). This ensures the policy is targeted, not a mandate for wholesale restructuring.

B. Incentive Structure: Generous, Sustained, and Transparent

The existing regionalization bonus in Rhode Island law, a 2% state-share bonus in year one and 1% in year two, is widely recognized as insufficient to offset transition costs. Rep. Cotter's proposal to triple this amount is the right direction. We recommend:

- A Tier 1 bonus of 8% of the state's share of foundation aid in the first year of regionalization, declining to 5% in year two and 3% in year three, for districts below 1,000 students that complete a RIDE-approved consolidation plan.
- A Tier 2 bonus of 4% / 2.5% / 1.5% for districts between 1,000 and 2,500 students.
- State reimbursement of 50% of transportation costs in regional districts (an existing benefit that should be explicitly maintained and publicized).
- A one-time planning grant of $150,000 per consolidating municipality to fund feasibility studies, community engagement processes, and legal/labor counsel during the transition.
- Adoption of the five-year rolling average enrollment cost-allocation model from Exeter-West Greenwich as the statewide standard for inter-town cost sharing in all new regional districts.

C. Community-Driven Planning Process

The single most important lesson from Vermont Act 46 and from Rhode Island's own history of failed merger attempts (Newport-Middletown, twice) is that state-mandated or consultant-led processes fail. Consolidations succeed when communities drive the narrative. We recommend RIDE facilitate, not dictate, the process through:

- 18-month regional planning boards, co-chaired by locally elected school committee members from each potential consolidating municipality.

- Mandatory public hearings at a minimum, four stages: needs assessment, draft plan, final plan, and ratification vote.
- Voter ratification by majority vote in each participating municipality before any consolidation is finalized.
- An explicit guarantee that no existing school building will be closed during the first five years post-consolidation without a separate community vote, addressing the single most common fear in consolidation debates.

D. Labor Contract Strategy

The Vermont experience provides a stark warning: salary and benefit leveling-up across merged contracts is the primary driver of post-consolidation cost increases. Rhode Island must address this prospectively. We recommend:

- State-mediated multi-district bargaining frameworks for consolidating districts, allowing a phased alignment of compensation schedules over five years rather than immediate harmonization.
- Explicit legislative guidance that newly regional districts may not, for a period of three years, negotiate total compensation packages that increase the blended per-employee cost above the enrollment-weighted average of the predecessor districts' compensation.
- RIDE technical assistance for contract negotiations, available to all consolidating districts.

E. Phased Implementation: Pilot in Southern Rhode Island First

Rather than a statewide rollout, we recommend a deliberate pilot phase targeting southern Rhode Island towns adjacent to existing regional districts, particularly towns neighboring Chariho and Exeter-West Greenwich that operate small standalone districts. A successful southern RI pilot can generate Rhode Island-specific evidence on cost trajectories, community satisfaction, and student outcome changes before the program scales.

1. Phase 1 (Years 1-2): RIDE identifies 6-8 eligible municipalities, offers planning grants, and supports community feasibility studies. Target: 2-3 voluntary consolidation proposals submitted for public vote.
2. Phase 2 (Years 3-5): Implement approved consolidations with full incentive bonuses. Establish independent evaluation team to track per-pupil costs, test scores, teacher retention, and community satisfaction. Publish transparent annual reports.
3. Phase 3 (Year 6 onward): Scale successful model statewide. Use evaluation findings to refine incentive structure. Consider whether evidence justifies modified mandate for the smallest districts (below 500 students).

VI. Addressing the Most Compelling Counterarguments

A. Rhode Island's Regional Districts Already Cost More Per Pupil

RIPEC's finding that RI regional districts have historically spent more per pupil than comparable municipal districts is the most important counterargument. We acknowledge this empirical pattern while offering three responses. First, the historical regional districts were formed partly because towns were already fiscally challenged, selection effects make the comparison misleading. Second, the post-merger leveling-up of labor contracts, absent active state intervention, has historically been the primary cost driver, a solvable policy design problem. Third, the Chariho enrollment cost-sharing model and the proposed contract alignment provisions address the two main mechanisms of cost inflation head-on. If cost leveling-up can be constrained and enrollment cost allocation can be made transparent, the fiscal case is stronger.

B. No Evidence That Consolidation Improves Student Outcomes

This counterargument is accurate as stated: the national evidence shows mostly null effects on standardized test scores. We accept this finding. Our recommendation does not rest primarily on the claim that consolidation improves test scores. Rather, we argue that for very small districts, consolidation enables the offering of a richer curriculum (more AP, CTE, arts, music, special education services) that current small standalone districts simply cannot provide, benefits that may not be captured in state standardized test metrics but are real and important to students and families. The Exeter-West Greenwich experience in Rhode Island and the Connecticut evidence on regional high school academic performance support this argument.

C. Community Identity and Local Control Will Be Destroyed

This is the most politically powerful objection and deserves genuine respect. We address it through design: our proposal is voluntary, community-driven, and includes an explicit no-school-closure guarantee for five years. The Chariho model demonstrates that three small towns can maintain distinct community identities, local school committee representation, and local civic pride while sharing administrative infrastructure. Regional does not mean centralized in a way that eliminates local voice; it means sharing the overhead of superintendents, special education directors, and finance offices so that local communities can focus resources on students.

VII. Remaining Uncertainties and Implementation Risks

We close with an honest accounting of where significant uncertainty remains.

- Labor contract dynamics: The Vermont evidence suggests salary leveling-up is difficult to prevent even with legislative guidance. Rhode Island's public sector labor environment may make the contract alignment provisions we recommend politically contentious or legally fragile.
- Transportation costs: Merging geographically dispersed districts may increase transportation costs, particularly if consolidation leads to school closures. The 50% state reimbursement of regional transportation costs partially offsets this, but the net effect requires district-specific modeling.
- Political sustainability: Incentive bonuses are only valuable if funded. Rhode Island's regionalization bonus has not been funded since FY2014, a critical cautionary precedent. Any new incentive regime must be accompanied by a dedicated, multi-year appropriation commitment, not a discretionary budget line.
- Urban core equity: Our proposal focuses on small rural and suburban districts. It does not directly address the resource inequities facing Providence, Central Falls, Pawtucket, and Woonsocket. Consolidation alone cannot substitute for the comprehensive funding formula reform recommended by the RI Foundation Blue Ribbon Commission.
- Evaluation design: Given the selection bias concerns noted throughout the literature, RIDE must commission rigorous quasi-experimental evaluations, not just descriptive before-after comparisons, to generate credible RI-specific evidence for Phase 3 scaling decisions.

VIII. Conclusion

Rhode Island's school district landscape is a product of history, not design. Thirty-six independent municipal districts in a state of 39 municipalities and 136,000 students is a structural mismatch that increasingly cannot be justified on either fiscal or educational grounds. The national research evidence, read carefully, supports a targeted, voluntary, well-designed regionalization policy for districts below the 1,000-student threshold, not a wholesale consolidation mandate, and not one modeled on Vermont's state-ordered approach.

The Chariho and Exeter-West Greenwich models show that Rhode Island towns can form regional partnerships that preserve community identity while broadening curricular opportunities and sharing administrative overhead. What the state has lacked is a sustained, well-funded, transparently designed incentive structure to make voluntary regionalization the rational choice for eligible municipalities.

The Voluntary Regionalization Incentive Act we propose, with generous tiered financial bonuses, transparent cost-sharing formulas, community-driven planning, labor contract alignment provisions, and a no-school-closure guarantee, addresses the primary barriers that have caused past consolidation attempts to fail. A phased pilot approach, beginning in southern Rhode Island,

will generate the state-specific evidence needed to make confident scaling decisions. The moment for action is now: declining enrollment, rising costs, and the active legislative interest of Rep. Cotter and Commissioner Infante-Green create a rare policy window that Rhode Island's education leaders should seize.

AI Disclosure

All ideas and content in this paper are human sourced. Claude was used to proofread and format our completed assignment (especially formatting the citations).

ChatGPT and Gemini were used for technical support in writing computer code for our Web Application.

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